MONTHLY UPDATE

Nigeria: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-31-2 · 176 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

Summary of the month

Across a single fortnight the identity commission converted the NIMC Act 2026 into bilateral operating agreements with the electoral commission, defence, solid minerals, trade, youth, women's affairs and the development bank; took over the national public key infrastructure as root certification authority; completed ICAO directory integration, making the passport cryptographically verifiable; and saw its number extended to airport boarding and farmer verification. No account of any of it states a lawful basis, consent mechanism or audit trail for the sharing involved.

The exchange went live on 30 July: a single sign-on Government Service Portal integrated with the national data exchange so agencies stop re-collecting citizen data.

In the courts, the data-protection regulator won its registration authority in the Federal High Court, a private claimant won damages without needing the regulator at all, and the digital-lending regulations that had been suspended since April were upheld and re-enforced.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

An Artificial Intelligence and Cyber Diplomacy Unit sits inside the foreign ministry, coordinating engagement on emerging technologies, established after the 2025 inaugural seminar.

Two coordination bodies were constituted in August, one with a deadline that tells you what it is. The Head of Service inaugurated an eleven-member technical working committee to coordinate the federal civil service's cabinet-approved digital transformation agenda, tasked with drafting the architecture, roadmap and governance mechanisms within one week ahead of a steering committee; no terms of reference, budget or publication commitment is stated. And a national strategy for the digital transformation of technical and vocational education was validated at an Abuja workshop by UNESCO, the education ministry and the technical education board, which named connectivity, teacher digital competency, financing and coordination as the gaps to close before implementation. Validated is not adopted, and neither text is held.

The month's substantive instrument is the cloud policy. On 17 August the communications ministry issued a National Digital Cloud Policy superseding the 2019 cloud policy, in force on publication apart from its sovereignty provisions, which await presidential approval. It makes cloud the default for new federal systems, with time-bound exemptions assessed by the IT development agency against published criteria and held in a register; pools ministry demand through the government infrastructure company into framework agreements bought on a National Digital Marketplace, with the procurement bureau overseeing compliance; and sorts government and regulated data into four levels — national-security data hosted only in Nigeria, financial, health, biometric and identity data stored at rest in Nigeria, internal operational records hybrid by prior authorisation, and public data unrestricted. Commercial data carries no general localisation duty, and a regulator has to apply for a category to be designated sovereign. The ministry states the 2019 Cloud First principle was applied unevenly for want of a coordinating framework, which is what the aggregation, marketplace, provider registration and compliance machinery is for. The policy text carries no published canonical link, and its relationship to the draft National Policy on Data and Cloud — five years in draft — is not stated.

Legislation and regulation

On 29 July a claimant won the first damages award under the Act — ₦15m, ₦500,000 costs and 10% post-judgment interest — against a bank that kept marketing after consent was withdrawn. Liability rested on three instruments at once. The court also held that personal data must be erased on termination but refused wholesale deletion where statutory banking and anti-money-laundering retention applies.

What the amended identity Act actually says reached the record on 11 August, in a law firm's reading rather than a gazetted text. On that reading the identity commission becomes the root certification authority for a national public key infrastructure and the national biometric-data repository; use of the national identification number is mandatory across passports, banking, telecommunications and land dealings, while the Act states that proof of identity is not proof of eligibility or of citizenship; and unauthorised database access carries at least NGN10m or five years for an individual and NGN20m for a body corporate. The base does not hold the Act itself, and the commission's own platform capacity for compulsory use across fourteen sectors is separately recorded as not sized for it.

The bench put its own view on the record. Fifty-four judicial officers adopted a communique calling for stricter authentication standards for AI-generated evidence and a review of the digital-evidence, cybercrime and privacy statutes, naming genuine evidence dismissed as AI-fabricated as an emerging problem, questioning whether clicking agreement is meaningful consent, and asking for electronic case management, virtual hearings and privacy-protected judicial platforms. A communique carries no legal force and no legislative response has followed.

The ECOWAS Community Court of Justice held that access to the internet is a right within the right to freedom of expression, and ordered Nigeria to pay N10 million to the journalist Jide Oyekunle over his assault, detention and phone seizure while covering a protest. The court traced the holding to two of its own earlier judgments, which makes this a settled regional position rather than a first ruling; nothing on file records compliance or payment.

The securities regulator's draft virtual-asset rules were reported in fuller detail on 31 August. They would require customer assets to be segregated from a firm's own with 80 per cent held offline, minimum paid-up capital of N2bn for digital-asset exchanges and custodians, a fidelity insurance bond covering at least 25 per cent of the applicable minimum, material incidents notified within 24 hours and reported in detail within 48, and SEC approval before a foreign-issued stablecoin may be listed. No commencement date or transition period is stated.

Data protection

On 28–29 July the Federal High Court upheld the data-protection commission's power to designate and register controllers and processors of major importance, dismissing a suit that had sought to place PoS agents outside the class; the commission immediately directed every unregistered entity to register. The judgment is not held and its delivery date is unestablished. The commission then used the power: on 13 August it opened a forensic investigation into a federal university, a bank and a technology vendor over the alleged use of students' personal data to open bank accounts without consent. No finding or penalty has followed.

Its other August move was institutional rather than adversarial: the commission and the securities regulator agreed to deepen collaboration on data-protection compliance in the capital market, the commission's head visiting the regulator in Abuja and being invited to its compliance summit. No memorandum, joint supervisory arrangement, compliance standard or enforcement commitment is stated.

A civil-society platform began watching the same election from the data side, tracking parties' websites and social media for privacy violations and access restrictions, piloted at the 15 August state governorship poll. No findings from the pilot are published.

Child protection online entered the record as a consultation rather than a rule. Nigeria is consulting on age limits, identity verification and platform liability, one of several African states moving from a minimum age for opening an account towards design duties on the platforms themselves, against an African Union child online safety policy of 2024 asking states to require protection by design and by default, risk assessments, researcher access to platform data and independent oversight. No draft instrument, closing date or responsible body is named, and the constraint reported across the region is enforcement rather than law.

An underground market trading national identity and bank verification numbers shut down after an investigative report named its operator, who remains a registered licensee of the data-protection commission. The closure and the licence surviving it are both the commission's own disposition; no enforcement notice against the operator is on file.

Regional collaboration

Ministers adopted an Abuja declaration on meaningful connectivity.

The continental data convention still has no Nigerian signature behind it: a peer-reviewed review of health-data governance in four countries records only Rwanda as a signatory, and finds all four frameworks fragmented with weak harmonisation of cross-border transfers. That is a finding about the record, carried as a dated absence.

The second meeting of the Africa Public Key Infrastructure Forum, held in Abuja, called for harmonised African rules so that digital credentials, electronic signatures and documents can be verified across borders. Nothing was adopted, and the base holds no instrument, timetable or signatory list behind the call.

Standards

The clearance gate over federal IT spending was quantified for the first time. The technology development agency's director-general told a bar association conference that it reviewed 1,092 project proposals from 326 ministries, departments and agencies between July 2023 and July 2026, worth more than N4.24 trillion, and cleared 1,056 of them worth N3.84 trillion — about N400bn and 36 proposals not cleared, on criteria and for reasons that are not published. He urged a Nigeria First approach in procurement so that public spending creates market for indigenous suppliers.

The standards move of the month is aimed at the innovation estate rather than at government systems. A draft National Innovation Hub Standards Framework went to an Abuja validation exercise, giving hubs a self-assessment tool across seven dimensions and about 35 categories and a defined maturity pathway, against a count of more than 339 hubs heavily concentrated in Lagos and Abuja — the stated purpose being to make a hub in a state outside those two legible enough to be funded without its founders relocating. At the same workshop the EU delegation put Team Europe support for the country's digital sector at more than €820m between 2021 and 2027. It is a draft at validation, so what the framework will require of a hub, and who will assess it, is not yet settled.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The month's one item is a formal demand rather than a policy change: a rights organisation and the Guild of Editors jointly called on 24 August 2026 for enforcement of the Cybercrimes Act to be suspended pending repeal or revision, arguing that the 2024 amendment failed to cure the defect the ECOWAS Court of Justice identified in 2022 when it ruled the original section 24 vague, arbitrary and in breach of the African Charter. No government or prosecutorial response is on file.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

Nothing was signed in this window that the base records. What entered it is an institutional fact rather than a development: the finance ministry's international economic relations department is the administrative home managing bilateral and multilateral economic relationships, memoranda of understanding and concessional financing, and it is the closest thing to an umbrella instrument the base holds. The page is undated on the ministry site and lists no relationship, agreement or financing volume.

New investments

A US$110m debt facility for technology startups opened for applications on 30 July.

The lending frame around all of it was settled earlier in the summer and its numbers reached the public in two different ways. The World Bank's Executive Directors endorsed the country partnership framework for FY26-FY32 on 29 June and approved a US$1.25bn development policy operation alongside it, whose reform programme includes modernising the regulatory framework for the digital economy and e-governance. The framework itself sets an indicative IDA envelope of about US$5.7bn over the IDA21 period on top of an ongoing programme of over US$16.9bn, and puts its digital commitment as broadband access for more than 58 million Nigerians against a stated baseline of 39% of the population using the internet in 2023 and fixed broadband penetration of 8.4% — and attaches no sum to that target. The sums circulating against it, a US$500m programme for resilient digital infrastructure and a second US$500m pipeline programme, come from a fact sheet handed out at a Lagos forum on 19 August rather than from the framework document, which the newspaper carrying them states on the record. A target with no line against it and a line with no document behind it are different problems, and this month produced one of each.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

An account published on 29 July puts about 101,000 km of fibre already built and finds that it bypasses some 130m Nigerians — a utilisation and last-mile finding sitting directly against the 90,000 km headline of the national fibre programme.

What is built is being cut faster than it is being protected. The regulator put fibre-optic cable cuts from road works at more than 5,000 in the first half of 2026 and stood up a standing committee with the works and communications ministries and the National Security Adviser's office to coordinate protection of fibre designated as critical national information infrastructure. No terms of reference, meeting cycle, budget or enforcement power is published for it.

The backbone programme meanwhile looked outward before it broke ground. Nigerian and Burkinabè digital ministries met in Ouagadougou on 12 August to explore connecting the planned 90,000 km open-access backbone into Burkina Faso, with a stated aim of halving internet costs through it. Nothing was signed, and physical deployment still stands at 2027 on the project documents.

On the tower estate, shareholders of the tower company approved the acquirer's cash buyout of the 75.3% it does not already own, the target's first-half revenue rising 8.2% to US$844m while rising Nigerian diesel costs and acquisition charges cut operating income 38%. Federal strategic review of the transaction is the last position the base holds on the state's side.

Two build programmes put dates on themselves. The government says resource mobilisation and contracting are complete for about 3,700 towers to be deployed from October for more than 20 million people in unserved and underserved communities, with the first being installed in Delta State and riverine communities targeted before mid-2027; no contract value or supplier is stated. Where fibre does not reach at all, an operator now runs nearly a dozen light-beam links across Lagos serving banks, hotels, internet providers and a utility, and plans to extend to Abuja, Ibadan and Kano. A state airport also activated a multi-gigabit backbone on 8 August over a commercial submarine-fibre network, to carry passenger processing, operations and real-time security monitoring.

The state also went back to orbit, and changed suppliers doing it. The Federal Executive Council approved the acquisition and deployment of two high-throughput communications satellites, NIGCOMSAT-2A and 2B, to be built by Thales Alenia Space and Israel Aerospace Industries on 22 August, with NIGCOMSAT-2A due by the end of 2028 and 2B in 2029 or 2030 on the operator's own timetable. The award breaks with the Chinese partnership that built NigComSat-1, which failed in November 2008, and NigComSat-1R, launched in 2011 and approaching the end of its fifteen-year design life, and sits alongside a January 2025 partnership with Eutelsat for low-earth-orbit services. No contract value is published and negotiation with the two manufacturers precedes manufacture.

Beneath all of that the licensed retail-ISP market is a rounding error and is concentrating. Regulator data released on 25 August put active licensed-ISP subscribers at 420,989 in June 2026, up 19.6% from 352,006 in December 2025, with three providers holding close to 70% of the market — Spectranet 111,384, Starlink 98,642 and FibreOne 56,486 — points of presence up from 2,508 to 2,893, and 126 of the 230 licensed ISPs reported to have a single active subscriber. The same data puts that whole market at 0.27% of the country's 156.4 million active internet subscriptions, which is the scale at which any argument about broadband competition here has to be read.

Katsina State began the last-mile stage of its fibre network, the state investment promotion agency coordinating with commercial providers to move from core installation to connections for homes, businesses and public facilities across all 34 local government areas, with right-of-way fees waived and a roadmap target of 2,000-3,000 km of fibre and 70 per cent broadband penetration for which no date is given. The satellite programme got its financing shape: the operator disclosed that NIGCOMSAT-2A and 2B will be vendor-financed and backed by export-import banks, with the amount official only once financing closes.

Data Storage

A Lagos cloud region entered service on 10 August, the third on its operator's platform alongside Lisbon and Johannesburg and presented around data residency since the Nigeria Data Protection Act took effect — three legal jurisdictions carried on one platform. It joins about 26 facilities carrying 50 to 56 MW live, a figure that reaches some 124 MW only when operators' design specifications are counted rather than declared capacity, Africa's second-largest market after South Africa at about 15% of continental capacity, most of it in Lagos.

The state put its own instrument behind the same argument on 5 August, signing the regulatory framework for a National Sovereign Cloud Initiative with the state-owned Galaxy Backbone, setting policy, technical and quality requirements for hosting government and business services in the country. It excludes nobody: the stated ask of Google, Microsoft and Amazon is a clearer path to local deployment. The dependence it is aimed at is more than 85% of national workloads running on public clouds, and 22% of the thousand most-visited sites hosted in Nigeria against a sub-Saharan average of 34%.

The sovereign cloud acquired its instruments and a start date. Four were signed on 4 August — a cloud computing guideline, a cloud technical guideline, a digital infrastructure assurance framework and a cloud investment strategy — with certification of cloud and artificial-intelligence infrastructure providers to begin in October, oversight vested in a new governance committee and a stated ambition to serve West and Central Africa. What certification will require of a provider is not published.

The month's largest capacity announcement is offshore-financed and not yet sited. The operator group named the UAE backer of its Africa Data Hub Holding vehicle on 27 August as Tarek Al Ashram, founder of the Dubai colocation operator Gulf Data Hub, with its own connectivity business a shareholder supplying open-access connectivity and go-to-market support, the vehicle having been named in the group's half-year results booklet three days earlier without the partner behind it. The first phase targets 150MW of AI-ready capacity across South Africa and Nigeria, with no split between the two countries, no Nigerian site, no cost and no commissioning date stated — a number to hold against the 50 to 56 MW the country's twenty-six existing facilities actually carry.

Energy

The regulator's own quarterly report is the first authoritative statement of grid reliability the base has carried for some time. Its first-quarter 2026 instalment records frequency and voltage outside the Grid Code range, 7.96 per cent transmission loss and 32.72 per cent plant availability, with a total grid collapse on 23 January and a partial collapse on 27 January. The document is statutory under section 56(3) of the Electricity Act 2023, which is what makes it a series rather than an announcement.

Technical Capacity

The identity authority's servers, databases and networks are not sized for compulsory use of the national identification number across the fourteen sectors the amended Act reaches — a compulsory register carrying a 2027 election-integrity risk if it cannot be relied on across that volume.

Cybersecurity

The communications regulator issued a Guidance Note on cybersecurity budgets on 7 August under a framework effective since 23 February, adding a dedicated budget line with tracked spend and periodic audit, requiring a Chief Information Security Officer, and restating two-year in-country retention of call logs and traffic data; the compliance clock ends 23 February 2027. Two further bodies are announced and no more: a Ministerial Advisory Council on Cybersecurity with no membership or terms of reference published, and a Payment Security Operations Centre set as a 2028 target with no legal basis, funding line or operator named. Where staffing did move it moved on a foreign programme: the national cybersecurity coordinator put a United Kingdom-funded bilateral partnership at more than 90 per cent implemented on 22 August, crediting it with the continent's first four SIM3-certified incident-response auditors at the national coordination centre, a reviewed national incident response plan and maturity frameworks for critical national information infrastructure. The completion figure is his own, and neither the memorandum nor the programme document is held.

DPI

Data Exchange

Nine agencies took bilateral cover under the amended identity Act inside a fortnight, among them Solid Minerals, the Presidency and Women Affairs and the Bank of Industry; no account states a lawful basis, consent mechanism or retention rule for the sharing that follows. The Nigeria Data Exchange now moves personal data between ministries in production behind the Government Service Portal, on the same silence. Against the single-source-of-truth framing, named practitioners describe the arrangement as federated linkage on a shared identifier, with banks still reconciling by hand. The National Single Window, launched in March, is contested by licensed customs agents who say clearance paperwork has multiplied rather than consolidated.

A state built its own exchange for the most sensitive category of all. Lagos set out a Smart Health Information Platform on 8 August, to connect patient records, laboratory results and biological data across facilities and to underpin an artificial-intelligence-driven health system, citing the Ebola and COVID-19 outbreaks as the case for moving off siloed facility records. No legal basis, data-controller arrangement, consent model, retention rule or relationship to the national data-protection regime is stated for it — the same silence the federal exchanges above are described in.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Identity gained infrastructure and kept its gap. The passport became cryptographically verifiable at 111 member states' borders on 16 July; the identity authority took the national root certification authority over from NITDA on 21 July; and V-Pass went live for airport security checks and boarding on the number and face biometrics. Registration stands at 136 million against a target of 180 million by 31 December, leaving about 100 million people uncaptured on the information minister's own figure. The root certification authority it took over also created a conflict: the NIMC Act 2026 makes the identity commission the root authority while the still-pending Digital Economy and E-Governance Bill carries its own electronic-signature provisions, and which instrument governs digital signatures is unresolved.

Two identity systems moved in opposite directions. The federal government signed a memorandum on 12 August to issue cooperatives a verification number and their members an identity credential, opening a six-month revalidation exercise, with no cooperative or member count, cost, or link to the foundational register stated. Against that, an observer mission at the state governorship election of 15 August called for a full post-election technical audit of the biometric voter-accreditation system, for the electoral commission to publish the causes of authentication failures, and for uniform guidance on downloadable voter cards before 2027. A second observer group reporting on the same poll named the failure modes — devices that would not boot, delaying one unit's opening to 09:45, fingerprint and facial capture failing on voters, elderly voters recurrently, so that they could not vote at all, slow processing at units of over 1,100 registered voters, an export failure, and one device that stopped altogether, and asked for the devices to be upgraded before 2027. Both accounts are observers' own, limited to the units their teams visited; no commission response, failure rate or audit commitment is on record.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Payments produced real-time reporting of every licensed bureau's FX purchases from 15 July.

On 2 August an account of African corporate venture capital recorded that tier-one Nigerian banks hold payments infrastructure inside the group rather than at arm's length, and that the central bank has begun regulating fintech ownership as well as conduct. The base carries no earlier statement of the ownership position, so no change can be stated.

The central bank then set out what it wants that infrastructure to look like. A circular imposes market-structure caps of 25% on card issuing and 15% on acquiring, mandatory localisation of payment data by 1 January 2027, and disclosure of ultimate beneficial owners on banks, fintechs and payment service providers, against an estimated US$850m a year spent on offshore hosting and about 90% of Nigerian payment data currently held abroad. Those figures are the analysing firm's estimates and the circular text itself is not held.

Three admission gates opened alongside it. The central bank opened a second sandbox cohort to virtual-asset and data-enabled firms, applications running 12 to 31 August, and chairs a new Virtual Asset Council with the securities regulator and the revenue service, against an estimated US$92.1bn transacted in cryptocurrency by Nigerians between July 2024 and June 2025; the securities regulator admitted two further firms to its incubation programme, taking it to 12 since July. Neither publishes a graduation route or licensing outcome. The regulated naira stablecoin went live on a public blockchain on 12 August, with no supply, holder count or reserve attestation published.

Taxation moved in the other direction. Peer-to-peer and over-the-counter traders warned on 14 August that the 1.5% virtual-asset stamp duty and the taxes beside it could push activity into unregulated channels, the rules having been signed on 31 July. Separately the Lagos State revenue service is testing whether creator-economy platform payouts are royalties subject to 5% withholding tax, pressing two named platforms to deduct at source under the 2025 tax act — the same authority's earlier attempt to make a ride-hailing platform a collection agent being the precedent. No assessment, ruling or judgment is published in either matter.

Two structural changes to the acceptance side arrived in mid-August. A Nigerian payments company gained direct access to a global card network as a non-bank acquirer, letting it onboard licensed merchants for card acceptance without a bank sponsor; no merchant count, pricing or settlement arrangement is stated, and the base holds no central bank statement on non-bank acquiring. And the channel mix reversed: ATM transactions rose 6.6% year on year in the first quarter of 2026 with value up 64.6% to NGN26.3tn, while point-of-sale volumes fell 19.9% to 2.92bn, the agent-banking limits of October 2025 — single-provider terminals, a 70-metre radius rule and a NGN1.2m daily cap — constraining the agent channel as the central bank pushes bank ATM expansion. That is a policy effect rather than a preference shift, and no measure exists of what it did to access in places with no bank branch.

The virtual-asset track kept admitting. Three further firms were named as admitted to the securities regulator's incubation programme in the week to 17 August, and a separate account describes the state coordinating the central bank, the securities regulator, the tax authority and the financial-intelligence agency into a regulatory consortium for virtual assets rather than restricting the sector, pairing the incubation programme and revised digital-asset capital requirements of NGN2bn for exchanges and custodians with an August virtual-asset tax framework. The counts across accounts overlap and are not reconciled.

The rail underneath all of it began to change. The clearing operator reports 26.55 million transactions worth 1.4 trillion naira across 48 institutions in the early phase of the ISO 20022-compliant stack that replaces the instant-payments system, on a multi-currency platform carrying payments, identity and data together. The figures are the operator's own.

The withdrawn credit product came back on 24 August. The dominant operator resumed airtime lending on four vendors after the April suspension that followed new consumer-watchdog licensing and consumer-protection requirements, with its lending base cut to about a quarter of its first-quarter run rate and a stated cost of about 50 billion naira (US$37.1m) to first-half revenue. The group expects the whitelisted customer base to rebuild through the third and fourth quarters — its own forecast, and no regulator statement on the resumption is held. The jurisdictional question the suspension turned on is unresolved and before the Court of Appeal.

Registries

Civil registration went nationwide from 1 July on a platform run as a public-private partnership, a private contractor carrying availability and security duties over the register of births and deaths.

Sectoral management information systems

Federal HR and payroll moved to a locally built platform across more than 508 ministries and more than 600,000 civil servants, justified explicitly as data sovereignty.

The federal payroll is to be audited from the outside. The President directed the finance minister on 28 August to coordinate a forensic audit of the integrated personnel and payroll information system and related payroll, pension and financial-management platforms - reconciling ghost-worker figures, tracing how ineligible persons were enrolled, reviewing access, identity, biometric and bank-account controls, and examining the interfaces with the financial management system and the Treasury Single Account, alongside a definitive inventory of every federal agency and its legal basis.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The Government Service Portal was soft-launched on 30 July as a single sign-on gateway built with Korean financing, piloted since 2025, the Korean agency named as a delivery partner alongside the communications ministry. Behind the login it integrates with the national data exchange so agencies share citizen data rather than each re-collecting it. The lawful basis and the audit arrangements are unstated, and no published rule answers either.

At state level a second donor took the policy layer rather than the platform: on 16 August the UK opened a digital policy and regulatory reform project with Ekiti State, to produce a digital-economy strategy, a DPI roadmap, a civic-technology strategy and a connectivity-reform framework. Its value and duration are not published.

Two more federal fronts opened in the same week. The communications ministry launched services.gov.ng as a single point of access to services previously spread across agency websites and offices — business registration, trade permits, identity verification, regulatory licensing and empowerment programmes — framed partly as a defence against fraudulent look-alike sites. No service count, transaction volume, cost or build attribution is published, and nothing states how it relates to the single sign-on portal soft-launched three weeks earlier. And on 19 August the IT development agency and the Hajj commission agreed to digitise pilgrimage operations end to end, from registration and payment verification to flight manifests, logistics and pilgrim tracking, the commission disclosing that its ICT function runs on two developers. It is an agreement to work together: no scope document, budget, timetable or procurement follows it.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Enugu opened free digital storefronts, company-registration support, digital-trade training and payment enablement to 1,000 state businesses with Afreximbank's trade platform; cost, funder and selection method are unstated.

Anambra began the second phase of its own state strategy, expanding its OneGov platform to digitise government services and formalise small and medium enterprises; the platform logged about 14,000 visits over three weeks in July despite limited publicity. Visits are not registrations or transactions, and no service count, formalisation figure or cost is stated. A development agency separately reaffirmed its support for the state's youth digital-skills programmes.

Rural digital data capture

The communications minister told the President on 4 August that deployment of about 3,700 towers begins around October, reaching more than 20 million people in communities with no telecoms service and with the capital stated as raised — no funding source, operator or contract is named. The baseline against which it is measured is 23% of rural communities connected to 57% urban.

Technology

AI

Nothing moved on the national AI policy, the risk-based regime inside the digital-economy bill, or the surveillance estate.

The activity was at the state level and abroad. Anambra State set out a Vision 2030 push on artificial intelligence and paperless government that its own ICT agency says is constrained by weak connectivity and computing capacity, with no budget, procurement, delivery date or named system published. The federal IT agency signed two memoranda in Toronto with Canadian firms on financial inclusion, local AI infrastructure, technology transfer and digital skills, and separately pushed a National Sovereign Cloud initiative against a stated position in which over 85% of workloads run on public cloud largely hosted abroad. None of the three carries a value, a timetable or a delivery commitment.

The month's one national artificial-intelligence programme is a vendor's. A platform company launched an AI Academy with the communications and digital economy ministry, the national skills programme, the artificial-intelligence research centre and a research network, combining a startup pitch competition, skills courses and a six-week developer bootcamp; ten startups are shortlisted to pitch at a Lagos exhibition on 3 September, with two winners receiving US$5,000 in cash, US$2,000 in the company's own advertising credits and a trip to its summit in Istanbul. No cohort size, curriculum, cost or public accounting of the sponsor's role is stated, and part of the prize is denominated in the sponsor's inventory.

The one domestically built model to ship this month went the other way, at a research conference rather than a ministry. A Nigerian startup released version 2.5 of its African speech-recognition model at the 2026 Deep Learning Indaba in Lagos, supporting bilingual recognition across 12 African language pairs and trilingual Kinyarwanda-English-French recognition, aimed at speakers who switch languages mid-sentence. The language-pair count and the error rates are the developer's own and no independent evaluation is held.

ICT Industry

Mobile money revenue at the largest operator grew about 132% in the first half and active wallets rose 1.3 million to five million, while suspending a single airtime-lending product took second-quarter fintech revenue to ₦12.99bn, down 72.4% year on year — establishing that the book the market had read as a payments business was substantially an airtime-lending business.

Innovation ecosystem

A drive-to-own vehicle financier raised US$250m at a US$2.1bn valuation on 5 August, financing a 42,000-vehicle fleet across fourteen countries against platform earnings — making ride-hailing income the credit-scoring and repayment rail for drivers outside formal banking, a class of alternative-data underwriting no Nigerian instrument addresses. The communications regulator leased its Digital Industrial Park and Learning Centre to Enugu State for fifteen years, its executive vice chairman saying that buildings alone do not create innovation; no rent, investment commitment or performance condition is stated. A crowdsourced food-price platform reports about 2,500 users.

NITDA inaugurated a Technical Working Group to build a multi-agency national regulatory sandbox, deliberately sector-agnostic, letting innovators test emerging technologies with several regulators at once before full market approval. It is distinct from the central bank's own sector sandbox, and no framework text, member list or timetable has been published.

Capacity

Training and skills

A diaspora health-workforce registry is described as newly launched, with no launch date, custodian agency, enrolment terms or data-protection basis stated in anything held — a register standing up ahead of its governance.

Inclusion

Access to services

A digital self-care platform went live for University of Lagos students, routing to free contraceptives through the state health ministry and UNFPA supply chain, with expansion to other Lagos campuses planned.

Away from the campuses, German cooperation opened a tender on 4 August for the IT equipment of rural job centres in Ogun and Plateau States, under a youth-employment project. A procurement notice fixes the equipment stage and nothing else: how many centres, at what cost, and when they open are all unstated.

The accessibility requirement is not reaching the platforms it binds. None of eight public websites audited in May 2026, among them the admissions board, the identity commission, the revenue service and the disability commission itself, had implemented baseline accessibility features; an earlier assessment of all 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory found 26 non-compliant with the technology agency's website guidelines and 14 sites unusable for people with disabilities; and the Nigeria Web Design Standards, launched in July 2025 with a toolkit promised within eight to ten weeks, had published none by August 2026 with no evidence of Federal Executive Council approval or of implementation. The commission's own estimate is 35 million Nigerians with disabilities.

Digital divides

A global memory-chip shortage was reported on 29 July as turning device cost into a divide variable in a market that imports nearly every computer it sells.

Nothing moved on the identity gender gap, on rural access, or on the schools programme whose January 2026 completion date passed undelivered.

Data

National statistics

An inclusive-data initiative brought the national statistics office into a five-country programme.

A state put a household survey at the centre of its budgeting. Katsina launched six planning documents on 28 August, among them a General Household Survey Report and a State Statistical Yearbook covering poverty, employment, livelihoods, agriculture, education, healthcare, housing, water, sanitation and access to basic services across its 34 local government areas, the budget commissioner directing agencies to align their programmes to the new frameworks.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The month's hyperscaler activity is a renewal rather than a new commitment. Google gave students at accredited Nigerian universities, polytechnics and colleges of education twelve months of its AI Plus plan free, a subscription it prices at ₦92,400 (US$68.56), the second consecutive year of the offer and one of 27 Sub-Saharan rollouts, with eligibility verified through a third-party enrolment-checking platform. No cohort figure is published for Nigeria, and the take-up of the equivalent 2025 offer is not stated, so the programme's reach is unmeasured at both ends.

China activities

On 27 August Huawei launched an agentic artificial-intelligence cloud in Nigeria at its own Lagos summit, running on local cloud infrastructure it offers with data residency, security, compliance and low-latency claims for finance, telecommunications, internet services, government and enterprises. The technology development agency's director-general used the platform to set out the National Sovereign Cloud Initiative as the route from consuming technology to leading African cloud and artificial-intelligence innovation, and the Lagos deputy governor said the state is building the digital foundations for artificial intelligence rather than waiting for it.

Sovereignty language attaching to a foreign vendor's platform is the pattern here rather than the exception: the same company's Lagos innovation centre opened in May 2025 to a ministerial framing as a catalyst for the country's technology sovereignty. No customer, contract, capacity or price is stated for the cloud launch, and the residency and compliance claims are the vendor's own.

EU activities

The European Union committed EUR 820m to the digital sector at the Abuja workshop that validated a national innovation hub standards framework, which would set one standard across the country's hubs. The envelope is stated at a workshop rather than in an instrument, the framework is validated rather than adopted, and neither carries a disbursement schedule or a hub count.

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